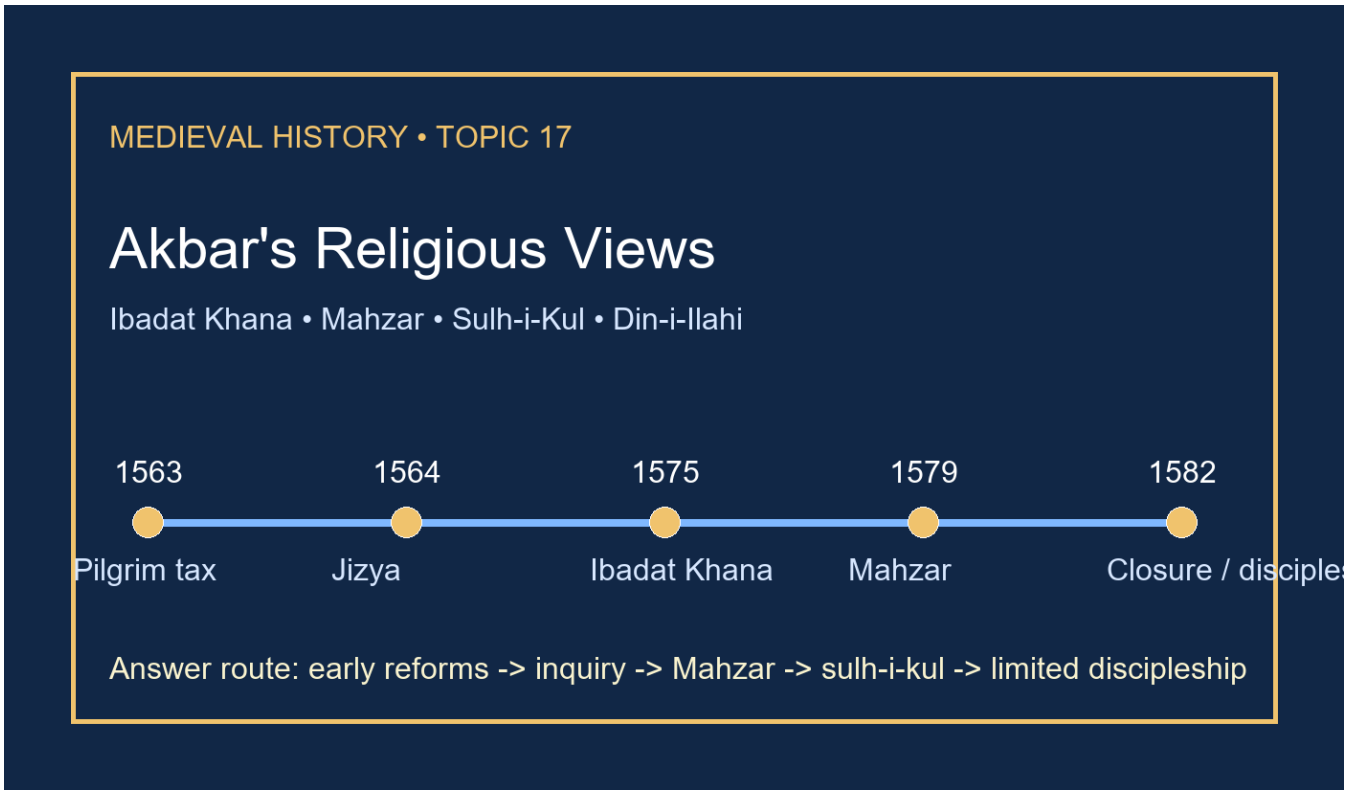
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Akbar's Religious Views: Ibadat Khana & Din-i-Ilahi - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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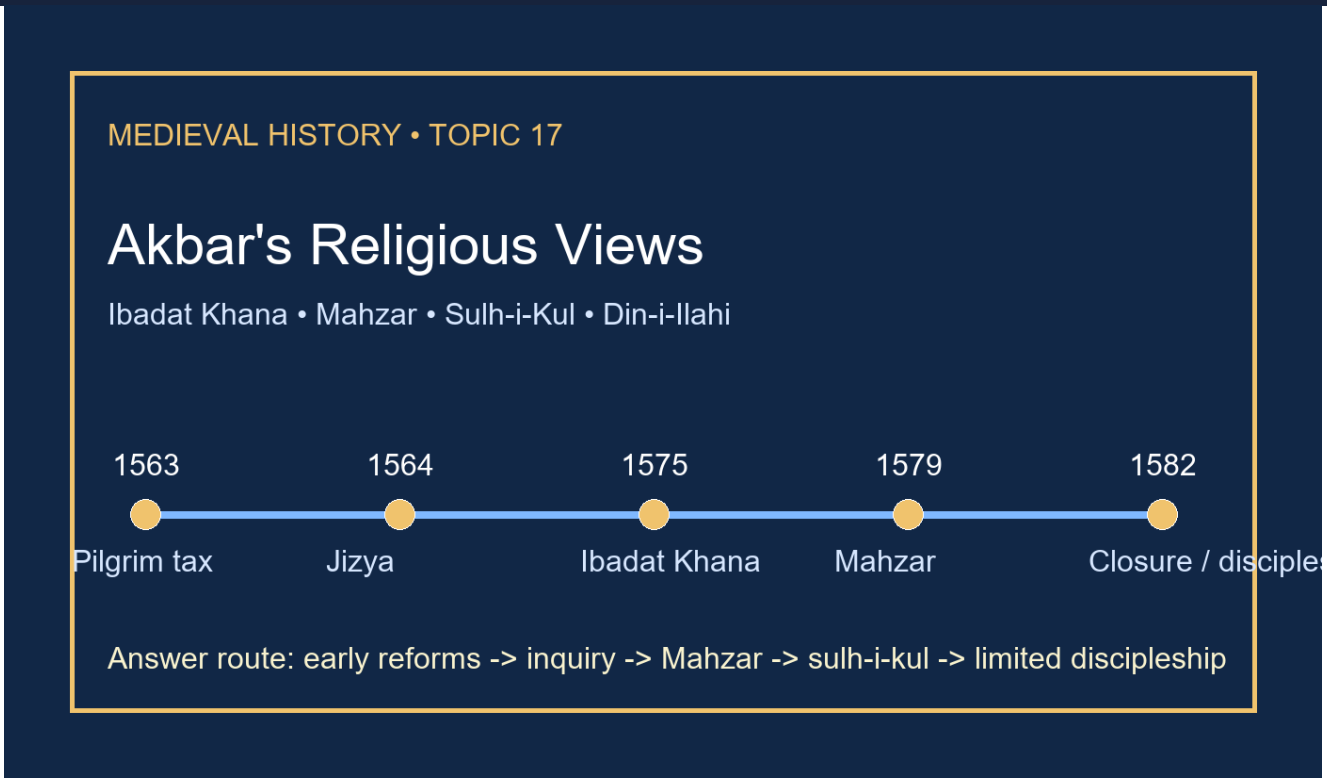
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Akbar's Religious Views: Ibadat Khana & Din-i-Ilahi - Solved Practice Workbook



Topic 17 workbook cover

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Workbook MCQ 1

Question: Which chronology is correct?

A. 1563 pilgrim-tax remission -> 1564 jizya abolition -> 1575 Ibadat Khana B. 1564 jizya abolition -> 1575 Ibadat Khana -> 1563 pilgrim-tax remission C. 1575 Ibadat Khana -> 1564 jizya abolition -> 1579 Mahzar D. 1579 Mahzar -> 1563 pilgrim-tax remission -> 1582 closure

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. The early fiscal measures came first and prepared the ground for later debate and arbitration.
- **B:** This sequence scrambles the 1563 and 1564 measures, so it breaks the chronology the topic rests on.
- **C:** The Ibadat Khana cannot precede the 1564 jizya abolition in the canonical timeline.
- **D:** Mahzar belongs to 1579, not to the start of the sequence, and the option also skips the 1575 debate-hall stage.

Examiner trap: The trap is a familiar set of right dates shuffled into the wrong order.

Workbook MCQ 2

Question: The Ibadat Khana in its first phase was chiefly a forum for

A. Portuguese missionaries B. Muslim scholars, Sufi shaikhs, learned men and court companions C. representatives of every Indian religion in equal numbers D. provincial diwans and bakhshis

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Jesuits entered later and never monopolised the forum.
- **B:** Correct. The original circle was court-centred and mainly Muslim, which is why later widening matters.
- **C:** Equal all-India representation is a modern fantasy, not a source-based description of 1575.

- **D:** These are administrative offices from Topic 16, not the participant circle of the debates.

Examiner trap: Students often project the later multi-faith phase backward onto the opening stage.

Workbook MCQ 3

Question: What does the Mahzar most safely signify?

A. Akbar became a prophet above Islam B. Every qazi lost all function forever C. The emperor could choose among conflicting juristic opinions for public welfare D. A new revealed scripture replaced earlier law

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Prophethood is nowhere the secure point of the document.
- **B:** The declaration narrowed clerical monopoly, but it did not erase the legal world below the emperor.
- **C:** Correct. The power is bounded and works within disagreement among already existing juristic views.
- **D:** Mahzar was a signed declaration, not a fresh sacred text.

Examiner trap: The word "infallibility" tempts candidates to inflate a legal-political document into theology without limits.

Workbook MCQ 4

Question: Sulh-i-kul should NOT be equated with

A. a policy of broad accommodation B. justice and public welfare C. a ruler-centred ethic of plural governance D. modern constitutional secularism

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Accommodation belongs to the term's political content.
- **B:** Justice and welfare are central to the Abu'l Fazl idiom surrounding sulh-i-kul.
- **C:** This wording is safe because it keeps the principle tied to imperial rule.
- **D:** Correct. Modern secularism rests on constitutional citizenship and institutional restraint absent from Akbar's monarchy.

Examiner trap: The language of peace with all sounds modern unless the early-modern imperial setting is restored.

Workbook MCQ 5

Question: Which translated work best anchors Akbar's comparative intellectual policy?

A. Mahabharata rendered as the Razmnama B. Fatawa-i-Alamgiri C. Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri D. Baburnama in Chagatai only

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Razmnama is the signature court example of Sanskrit epic entering the Persianate sphere.
- **B:** This belongs to Aurangzeb's later legal world, not Akbar's translation bureau.
- **C:** Jahangir's memoir matters for another reign, not for the Maktab Khana.
- **D:** Baburnama belongs to an earlier Mughal literary context and does not define Topic 17's translation programme.

Examiner trap: A familiar Mughal title can distract from the specifically translation-based evidence owned here.

Workbook MCQ 6

Question: The debates in the Ibadat Khana mattered historically because they

A. ended all doctrinal disagreement B. exposed clerical conflict and pushed Akbar toward a wider non-sectarian principle C. converted the court into a Christian mission station D. created an elected council of religions

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The opposite happened: disputes sharpened, which is why closure became part of the story.
- **B:** Correct. The failure of concord and the exposure of sectarian arrogance helped move Akbar toward sulh-i-kul.
- **C:** Jesuit participation formed one strand of encounter, not the meaning of the institution.
- **D:** No source supports a representative electoral body.

Examiner trap: The question tests whether you can explain consequence without pretending the debates themselves were harmonious.

Workbook MCQ 7

Question: Which statement best qualifies Tauhid-i-Ilahi / Din-i-Ilahi?

A. It replaced Islam across the empire B. It lacked every form of practice C. It was a small discipleship circle without scripture or priesthood D. It functioned as a public congregational church

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The circle never approached empire-wide replacement.
- **B:** That goes too far in the other direction, since initiation, greeting formulas and graded devotion are reported.
- **C:** Correct. This formula preserves both the absence of mass institutions and the presence of restricted practice.
- **D:** Congregational church-like organisation is exactly what the evidence does not support.

Examiner trap: Two opposite exaggerations are offered so that only a balanced middle answer survives.

Workbook MCQ 8

Question: How should Badauni be used?

A. As the neutral court ideologue of sulh-i-kul B. As a witness whose account needs no qualification C. As a source to discard because he opposed Akbar D. As a valuable hostile contemporary whose polemic must be read critically

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** That role belongs far more closely to Abu'l Fazl.
- **B:** His testimony is important, but not unfiltered truth.
- **C:** Discarding him entirely would throw away one of the sharpest internal critiques of court innovation.
- **D:** Correct. His hostility is exactly what makes him informative and limited at the same time.

Examiner trap: The examiner wants source method, not simple loyalty to either Abu'l Fazl or Badauni.

Workbook MCQ 9

Question: A source-based detail about the Ibadat Khana meetings is that Akbar commonly attended them on

A. Thursday nights after state business B. Friday noon after khutba C. Sunday dawn before the court opened D. Tuesday afternoons during revenue review

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Thursday night is the reported rhythm attached to the debates.
- **B:** Friday noon imports a prayer association that is not the highlighted source detail.
- **C:** Sunday belongs more to reported initiation settings than to the normal debate schedule.
- **D:** Revenue review belongs to administrative imagination, not to the religious-discussion timetable.

Examiner trap: A precise but minor detail is used to check whether the topic has been read, not merely summarised.

Workbook MCQ 10

Question: Which statement best captures the closure of the Ibadat Khana?

A. All interfaith contact ended forever B. Public debate declined around 1581-82, but private inquiry and translation continued C. Closure happened before the forum ever widened D. The hall became a permanent church after closure

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Closure of one public institution did not cancel missions, translations or private conversations.
- **B:** Correct. This preserves both the end of the formal forum and the survival of comparative engagement.
- **C:** The chronology is reversed here; widening came first.
- **D:** Nothing in the evidence supports transformation into a Christian institution.

Examiner trap: Candidates often mistake closure of the forum for closure of Akbar's wider intellectual search.

Workbook MCQ 11

Question: Hiravijaya Suri belongs primarily to which encounter strand?

A. Zoroastrian fire symbolism B. Jesuit textual mission C. Jain contact and petitions around animal life D. Ottoman political diplomacy

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** That route points toward Parsi discussions, not Hiravijaya Suri.
- **B:** Jesuit missions involved different named participants altogether.
- **C:** Correct. Hiravijaya Suri is the strongest named Jain anchor in this topic.
- **D:** Ottoman diplomacy belongs to a different political field.

Examiner trap: The question mixes named figures from different traditions to test whether the encounter map is secure.

Workbook MCQ 12

Question: What is the safest reading of Jesuit missions at Akbar's court?

A. They prove Akbar accepted baptism B. They came from Goa and reveal Christian encounter without proving conversion C. They replaced the Mahzar as the law of the empire D. They show Christianity became compulsory at Fatehpur Sikri

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Missionary hope is exactly what must be filtered out before drawing conclusions.
- **B:** Correct. Goa anchors the missions historically, while conversion remains unproved.
- **C:** Jesuit presence never displaced imperial or Islamic-legal mechanisms of rule.
- **D:** Compulsion is absent from the evidence and contradicts the limited courtly nature of the encounter.

Examiner trap: Jesuit presence tempts a leap from curiosity to conversion that the sources do not warrant.

Workbook MCQ 13

Question: Why can sun or fire reverence not be treated as automatic proof of Akbar's Zoroastrian conversion?

A. Because solar imagery was unknown in Persia B. Because Akbar never heard any Parsi teaching C. Because light symbolism also had Islamic philosophical and Sufi genealogies D. Because all such reports were written in the nineteenth century

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Persia is precisely one of the worlds in which fire and light symbolism remained meaningful.
- **B:** The issue is not total absence of contact; it is the danger of exclusive inference.
- **C:** Correct. Multiple intellectual lineages make a single-source reading unsafe.
- **D:** The evidence is much earlier and varied; the problem is interpretation, not total absence.

Examiner trap: Symbolic borrowing is being tested against exclusive-causation reasoning.

Workbook MCQ 14

Question: Which statement on membership is safest?

A. Every mansabdar joined Din-i-Ilahi B. The circle was very small and Birbal is the prominent Hindu name usually cited C. Membership is known from a full imperial census D. All Rajput rulers entered the fellowship

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Service rank and discipleship must not be merged.
- **B:** Correct. The small scale and the Birbal reference are exactly why the mass-religion thesis collapses.
- **C:** The best-known counts are later scholarly reconstructions, not state censuses.
- **D:** Rajput political alliance never translated into universal devotional membership.

Examiner trap: Candidates who confuse composite nobility with discipleship will overstate both scale and reach.

Workbook MCQ 15

Question: Abu'l Fazl's preferred expression for Akbar's late ethical-spiritual experiment is

A. Din-i-Ilahi B. Mahzar-i-Akbari C. Tauhid-i-Ilahi D. Shariat-i-Jadid

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The label existed, but it is more strongly associated with Badauni and later/hostile naming traditions.
- **B:** Mahzar refers to the 1579 declaration, not to the discipleship circle.
- **C:** Correct. Tauhid-i-Ilahi foregrounds divine monotheism in Abu'l Fazl's vocabulary.
- **D:** No such canonical label governs this topic in the audited owner sources.

Examiner trap: Terminology itself is part of the evidence and can decide an MCQ.

Workbook MCQ 16

Question: The background to the Mahzar included

A. Portuguese revenue demands in Goa B. a settled consensus among the ulama C. only an abstract wish to imitate the papacy D. juristic disagreement, grant controversies and imperial need for arbitration

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Goa belongs to Jesuit encounter, not to the Mahzar's internal background.
- **B:** If consensus had existed, the need for such a declaration would have been far weaker.
- **C:** This imports a simplistic European comparison that ignores Mughal court conflict.
- **D:** Correct. The Mahzar grew out of legal dispute, patronage conflict and expanding sovereignty.

Examiner trap: The item checks whether the Mahzar is rooted in Mughal institutional history rather than loose analogy.

Workbook MCQ 17

Question: Khairpura, Dharmapura and Jogipura are most useful as evidence for

A. court-centred welfare and multi-community provision B. the census of Din-i-Ilahi disciples C. the order of Mughal provinces D. the branding of cavalry horses

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. These establishments show accommodation operating through provision and patronage.
- **B:** They belong to institutional welfare and patronage, not to discipleship membership records.
- **C:** Provincial order is a Topic 16 concern and uses different terms entirely.
- **D:** Horse branding belongs to dagh, outside the religious-policy theme.

Examiner trap: Named institutions are used here to see whether you can sort religious-policy evidence from administrative vocabulary.

Workbook MCQ 18

Question: Shast is best described with caution as

A. a provincial land schedule B. an initiation-related token or object in reported discipleship practice C. the Persian title of the Ramayana D. the seal of the Mahzar

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Revenue schedules belong to agrarian assessment, not to Akbar's late courtly fellowship.
- **B:** Correct. The secure point is initiation-related association, not a fully systematised universal ritual code.
- **C:** Ramayana translations belong to the Maktab Khana, not to initiation paraphernalia.
- **D:** Mahzar is a juristic declaration and has no necessary link to shast.

Examiner trap: The word is unfamiliar enough that many readers misfile it into revenue or legal documentation.

Workbook MCQ 19

Question: The four degrees of devotion involved readiness to sacrifice

A. grain, water, labour and tax B. book, temple, mosque and church C. property, life, honour and religion D. zabt, kankut, batai and nasaq

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** These belong to agrarian imagination, not to the moral vocabulary of the discipleship circle.
- **B:** The reported degrees are about personal devotion and loyalty, not about listing institutions of worship.
- **C:** Correct. This sequence captures the source-reported hierarchy of commitment.
- **D:** Those are revenue methods from Topic 16 and cannot answer a question on late Akbarian devotion.

Examiner trap: The correct answer survives only if the candidate truly remembers the phrase, not the general theme.

Workbook MCQ 20

Question: Which topic boundary is most accurate?

A. Topic 17 owns detailed conquest campaigns B. Topic 17 owns religious policy and ideological integration, while Topic 15 and 16 own conquest and administration C. Topic 17 owns the whole Deccan question D. Topic 17 replaces Topic 24 on Mughal culture entirely

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Conquest chronology belongs primarily to Topic 15 and enters here only as background.
- **B:** Correct. This boundary statement preserves the separate ownership of conquest, administration and broader culture while keeping Topic 17 focused.
- **C:** The Deccan to 1657 belongs to Topic 18 and must not be swallowed here.
- **D:** Topic 24 still owns the wider survey of Mughal culture beyond the translation-policy angle.

Examiner trap: Ownership discipline is itself examinable because weak answers wander into adjacent Mughal topics.

Workbook MCQ 21

Question: Akbar's translation programme should be described as

A. an elite and mediated bridge of comparative knowledge B. a public literacy movement that erased social hierarchy C. proof that every community accepted one doctrine D. a purely decorative literary hobby unrelated to rule

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. The translations mattered intellectually and politically, but they remained courtly and mediated.
- **B:** There is no basis for projecting universal access or the end of hierarchy from the bureau.
- **C:** Shared textual circulation is not the same thing as doctrinal consensus.
- **D:** Calling it decorative misses how imperial knowledge and comparative inquiry were being institutionalised.

Examiner trap: The bureau is easy to romanticise unless its elite courtly scale is kept visible.

Workbook MCQ 22

Question: Akbar's social-reform regulations are best used as evidence of

A. uniform transformation across all regions B. imperial prescriptions whose implementation still needs separate proof C. proof that hierarchy vanished from Mughal society D. matters irrelevant to Topic 17

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Uniformity is the exact claim the owners warn you not to make from imperial orders alone.
- **B:** Correct. The regulations reveal intention and direction, but social reach must be argued with caution.
- **C:** Mughal hierarchy remained strong in gender, rank and coercive power despite reformist gestures.
- **D:** They belong here because religious-ethical governance includes social regulation and its limits.

Examiner trap: The item separates policy intent from verified social transformation.

Workbook MCQ 23

Question: Which evidence most clearly limits a celebratory reading of Akbarian tolerance?

A. Razmnama translation B. pilgrim-tax remission C. Chittor, rebellion punishment and continuing hierarchy D. the presence of Jesuits at court

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Translation expands intellectual contact, but it does not by itself expose the harder coercive edge of empire.
- **B:** This measure supports inclusion rather than directly highlighting its limits.
- **C:** Correct. Coercive episodes and hierarchy prevent the topic from being written as pure liberal harmony.
- **D:** Jesuit presence speaks to encounter; it does not provide the strongest corrective to over-celebration.

Examiner trap: The question tests whether you can insert coercion into a topic often remembered only for tolerance.

Workbook MCQ 24

Question: Jahangir's relation to Akbar's religious legacy is best described as

A. immediate reimposition of jizya in 1605 B. a total rejection of all Akbarian accommodation C. mass expansion of Din-i-Ilahi D. broad continuity in accommodation without identical continuation of the discipleship circle

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Jizya reimposition belongs much later under Aurangzeb, not to Jahangir's accession.
- **B:** This exaggerates rupture and ignores the broader afterlife of accommodation.
- **C:** The discipleship circle did not spread as a durable mass fellowship after Akbar.
- **D:** Correct. Continuity survived more in governing idiom than in the precise ritual form of the late fellowship.

Examiner trap: Legacy questions are easy to flatten into either pure continuity or total rupture.

Workbook MCQ 25

Question: The main limitation of Abu'l Fazl as a source is that he writes from

A. a courtly project legitimising Akbar's rational-spiritual kingship B. Jesuit missionary frustration C. village-level peasant memoir D. a nineteenth-century nationalist archive

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Abu'l Fazl's value lies in detail and ideology, but his panegyrical position shapes emphasis.
- **B:** That limitation belongs to Jesuit writings, not to Abu'l Fazl.
- **C:** He is the opposite of a peasant memoirist: he writes from the imperial centre.
- **D:** The source is contemporary Mughal, not nationalist-modern.

Examiner trap: Some candidates think "court source" means useless; the real issue is situated value plus situated bias.

Workbook MCQ 26

Question: The Ibadat Khana is textually associated with

A. Humayun's tomb and Delhi B. the court zone near Anup Talao and Shaikh Abdullah Niyazi's cell C. the Portuguese quarter of Goa D. the Lahore fort after 1605

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Delhi enters a different Mughal architectural world and is unrelated to the Fatehpur Sikri debate setting.
- **B:** Correct. This is the safest location description when combined with the warning that exact material identification remains debated.
- **C:** Goa matters for Jesuit missions, not for the location of the Ibadat Khana.
- **D:** Lahore belongs to later geography, not to the 1575 debate-hall context.

Examiner trap: Topographical precision is rewarded only when it stays within the source caution built into the advanced owner.

Workbook MCQ 27

Question: Which statement about the Mahzar is most accurate?

A. It authorised Akbar to create any creed he wished B. It made him the head of a universal church C. It strengthened imperial arbitration without claiming prophethood D. It abolished all Islamic legal vocabulary from statecraft

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The Mahzar never offered unlimited doctrinal invention.
- **B:** Church-headed language is anachronistic and distorts the Mughal-Islamic context.
- **C:** Correct. Imperial sovereignty grows here, but within a limited legal-political frame.
- **D:** Islamic vocabulary remains present in the document and in Akbar's larger political language.

Examiner trap: The right answer survives only if sovereignty is distinguished from prophethood.

Workbook MCQ 28

Question: Why is the label "Din-i-Ilahi" itself a topic of caution?

A. It was the name of a revenue schedule B. It refers to a fortification line in Gujarat C. It appears nowhere outside European travel writing D. It is more prominent in Badauni, Jesuit-associated and later framing than in Abu'l Fazl's preferred terminology

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Revenue schedules belong elsewhere and have nothing to do with late Akbarian discipleship.
- **B:** Military geography is being smuggled in from the wrong topic family.
- **C:** The label is broader than European writing alone, though it certainly travels through hostile and later narratives.
- **D:** Correct. Terminology is historical evidence here because competing labels reveal competing interpretations.

Examiner trap: Many answers lose precision by treating Tauhid-i-Ilahi and Din-i-Ilahi as unproblematic synonyms.

Workbook MCQ 29

Question: Which contrast correctly distinguishes Ibadat Khana from sulh-i-kul?

A. Ibadat Khana was a volatile forum of debate; sulh-i-kul was a more durable principle of governance B. Ibadat Khana was a tax; sulh-i-kul was a military office C. Ibadat Khana named Akbar's discipleship order; sulh-i-kul was the Mahzar D. Both terms describe one identical institution

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. One is a forum, the other a broader governing ethic that survived beyond it.
- **B:** Neither term belongs to fiscal extraction or military office-holding.
- **C:** This fuses three distinct strands of the topic into one inaccurate formula.
- **D:** The entire question exists to test whether the student can keep these categories separate.

Examiner trap: Close-option confusion between debate hall, governing principle and discipleship is one of the core prelims risks.

Workbook MCQ 30

Question: Which answer route best fits the 2025 GS-I question on Akbar's religious syncretism?

A. Start with Aurangzeb and move backward B. Use early fiscal inclusion -> Ibadat Khana inquiry -> Mahzar -> sulh-i-kul -> limited Tauhid-i-Ilahi C. List Mughal paintings and gardens only D. Explain mansabdari and dahsala in detail

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Backward comparison can qualify a conclusion, but it cannot replace Akbar's own direct chronology and aspects.
- **B:** Correct. This route answers "main aspects" with layered evidence and a built-in qualification.
- **C:** Art and garden description ignores the owning content of debate, sovereignty and accommodation.
- **D:** That route belongs mainly to Topic 16 and would miss the directive almost entirely.

Examiner trap: The 2025 PYQ punishes broad Mughal narration unless the answer is routed through Topic 17's own layers.

Workbook MCQ 31

Question: What was the verified 2026 outcome for Topic 17 after searching the mandated local paper and routing roots?

A. A direct prelims question on the Mahzar was verified B. A direct mains question on Din-i-Ilahi was verified C. No relevant 2026 Topic-17-owned question was verified locally D. A direct 2026 objective key on sulh-i-kul was found

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The required search did not produce such a locally verified prelims item.
- **B:** No locally verified 2026 mains wording on Topic 17 appeared in the mandated roots.
- **C:** Correct. The honest outcome is absence, and the repair record has to state that explicitly.
- **D:** There is no verified 2026 objective key for a Topic 17 question in the searched repositories.

Examiner trap: The 2026 rule tests audit honesty: absence must be recorded as absence, not filled with a guessed route.

Workbook MCQ 32

Question: Which final verdict is strongest?

A. Akbar created modern secular democracy B. The whole policy was only cynical fraud C. The entire experiment can be reduced to private mysticism D. Akbar joined inquiry, bounded sovereignty and plural imperial integration in a ruler-centred, hierarchical project

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Constitutional democracy, citizenship and institutional secularism are anachronistic here.
- **B:** Pure cynicism cannot account for the breadth of inquiry, translation and ideological experimentation.
- **C:** Private spirituality mattered, but it cannot absorb the fiscal, legal and political dimensions.
- **D:** Correct. This verdict keeps achievement, statecraft and limit together in one balanced judgment.

Examiner trap: The last question checks whether the candidate can hold complexity together instead of choosing a moral caricature.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified/routed 2026 status for Topic 17

- Searched the mandated 2026 official-paper and routing roots listed in the audit brief.
- Result: no direct Topic-17-owned 2026 question was verified locally, so the workbook retains only transparent pre-2026 support items plus original mains practice.

PYQ 1 - UPSC Mains GS-I 2025 (direct route)

Paper route evidence: `attempts\_pyq_text\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 1.txt` preserves the exact wording at line 13, and `_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2024-2025.md` routes 2025 GS-I Q2 to `Medieval-Indian-History/basic/17_Akbar-Religious-Views-Din-i-Ilahi.md` as the owning topic.

Question: *Examine the main aspects of Akbar's religious syncretism.* (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer: Akbar's religious syncretism was a layered imperial programme rather than the sudden creation of a new mass faith. First, he reduced visible religious disabilities by remitting pilgrim tax in 1563 and abolishing jizya in 1564. Second, the Ibadat Khana at Fatehpur Sikri widened inquiry from Muslim scholars to Hindu, Jain, Christian and Zoroastrian interlocutors, even though the debates ended in bitterness. Third, the Mahzar (1579) gave Akbar a bounded right to choose among conflicting juristic opinions for public welfare, not unlimited infallibility. Fourth, sulh-i-kul turned justice and non-sectarian accommodation into a principle of rule, reinforced by a composite nobility and translation projects such as the Razmnama. Finally, Tauhid-i-Ilahi / Din-i-Ilahi remained a tiny elite discipleship with no scripture or priesthood. Thus Akbar's syncretism integrated a plural empire, but remained ruler-centred, hierarchical and far from modern secular equality.

Demand decoding: This direct 10-mark mains question asks for the "main aspects" of syncretism. The answer therefore needs compact coverage of multiple layers rather than an essay on only Din-i-Ilahi or only tolerance.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Use five compressed anchors in order: 1563-64 fiscal opening -> Ibadat Khana inquiry -> Mahzar -> sulh-i-kul -> limited Tauhid-i-Ilahi. Reserve the last line for the hierarchy/dependence qualification.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because each aspect is attached to named evidence and because the conclusion rejects both the mass-religion myth and the modern-secularism anachronism.

How to improve/strengthen: If extra space existed, add one named interfaith example such as Hiravijaya Suri or the Razmnama to deepen the "syncretism" dimension without upsetting the 150-word balance.

PYQ 2 - UPSC Mains GS-I 2020 (adjacent source-method route)

Paper route evidence: `_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md` routes 2020 GS-I Q12 - "Persian literary sources of medieval India and the spirit of the age" - to Topic 24. It is retained here as an adjacent support item because Abu'l Fazl, Badauni and translation evidence are indispensable source families inside Topic 17 answers.

Question: *Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment.* (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer: Persian literary sources reveal medieval India not simply by narrating events but by preserving the ideological language through which courts understood power, faith and society. In the Akbar period, Abu'l Fazl's *Akbarnama* and *Ain-i Akbari* are crucial because they articulate kingship, sulh-i-kul and court order. Badauni's

Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh records unease over debate and innovation. Read together, these texts show that the age was not one of unanimous harmony but of contested sovereignty and competing orthodoxies. Persian translation activity under Akbar, including the Razmnama, also reflects a courtly appetite for comparative knowledge. Yet these texts remain elite productions. They illuminate the courtly "spirit of the age" more clearly than village reception or social implementation. Thus Persian literary sources are indispensable, but they must be read comparatively and critically, especially in topics like Akbar's religious policy where ideology and polemic are built into the evidence.

Demand decoding: The directive "comment" needs interpretation, not a list of titles. For Topic 17 use, the focus should be on what Persian sources reveal about kingship, controversy and comparative knowledge.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Name Abu'l Fazl first, contrast him with Badauni, then add translation activity as a third evidentiary block. End with a caution on elite perspective.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: This route earns marks because it moves from source identification to evidentiary value and bias. It also honestly preserves the item's adjacent status rather than falsely claiming direct ownership.

How to improve/strengthen: To strengthen it further, add one line distinguishing normative court ideology from uneven provincial and social implementation.

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks, 150 words

Question: Trace the evolution of Akbar's religious policy from early accommodation to sulh-i-kul. (Answer in 150 words)

Model answer: Akbar's religious policy evolved through connected stages rather than a single doctrinal break. The early phase centred on accommodation: pilgrim tax was remitted in 1563 and jizya abolished in 1564, signalling that non-Muslim subjects need not bear those fiscal disabilities in a widening empire. From 1575 the Ibadat Khana turned personal inquiry into public dispute; after 1578 the forum widened beyond Muslim circles but exposed the limits of courtly consensus. The Mahzar of 1579 then gave Akbar a bounded arbitral role among conflicting juristic opinions. Out of this sequence emerged sulh-i-kul: justice and non-sectarian accommodation as an imperial principle. Thus the policy moved from selective reform to a broader state ideology, while remaining ruler-centred and socially uneven.

Demand decoding: "Trace" requires chronology with analytical transitions.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Write in four steps: early reforms -> Ibadat Khana -> Mahzar -> sulh-i-kul.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because chronology itself becomes the explanation of policy development.

How to improve/strengthen: Add the 1581-82 closure point if you want to sharpen the move from public debate to governing principle.

Original Mains 2 - 10 marks, 150 words

Question: Why did the Ibadat Khana debates fail as dialogue yet matter for Mughal statecraft? (Answer in 150 words)

Model answer: The Ibadat Khana failed as dialogue because a royal court was a poor setting for equal theological exchange. Built at Fatehpur Sikri in 1575, it first gathered Muslim scholars, Sufis and learned men; later, after 1578, Hindu, Jain, Christian and Zoroastrian interlocutors also entered. Instead of convergence, the debates sharpened disputes over revelation, legal authority and superiority. Yet the debates mattered deeply for statecraft. They convinced Akbar that rival truth-claims could not be governed by one clerical monopoly alone. This intellectual crisis helped prepare the Mahzar and later the broader principle of sulh-i-kul. Even after public closure around 1581-82, private inquiry and translation continued. Therefore the Ibadat Khana mattered less as a successful interfaith institution than as the failed forum out of which a more durable imperial policy of accommodation emerged.

Demand decoding: The word "why" here has two parts: why failure happened, and why that failure still mattered.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Use one short paragraph on failure and one on political consequence.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because it answers both halves instead of narrating only the debates themselves.

How to improve/strengthen: If space permits, mention Thursday-night court setting or the 1578 widening to add sharper factual texture.

Original Mains 3 - 15 marks, 250 words

Question: Assess the Mahzar of 1579 as an assertion of imperial sovereignty. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: The Mahzar of 1579 was an assertion of imperial sovereignty, but its scope must be described with care. It was a declaration signed by leading ulama stating that where qualified jurists disagreed, the emperor could choose among existing opinions for the welfare of mankind and proper administration. Therefore it did not make Akbar a prophet, pope or unlimited maker of sacred law. Its political significance was still considerable. The Ibadat Khana had exposed sharp disagreement among court scholars, while issues of punishment and madad-i-maash grants made religious authority an institutional question. By placing final arbitration with the emperor, the Mahzar reduced the ability of rival clerical networks to claim the last word against imperial policy. At the same time, it should not be presented as an anti-Islamic rupture. It worked through juristic disagreement and within an Islamic political vocabulary. The best verdict is that the Mahzar strengthened ruler-centred arbitration inside a legal-moral frame and prepared the path toward sulh-i-kul without authorising boundless religious infallibility.

Demand decoding: "Assess" needs scope plus consequence.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Define the declaration first, then analyse its force, then qualify it with Islamic framing and hostile reaction.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because the answer begins with boundaries before moving to significance.

How to improve/strengthen: Mention the welfare-and-order clause explicitly if an examiner appears to be testing close textual precision.

Original Mains 4 - 15 marks, 250 words

Question: Explain how Akbar's translation programme became part of his religious policy. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: Akbar's translation programme became part of religious policy because it transformed comparative curiosity into an institution of imperial knowledge. Through the Maktab Khana, works such as the *Mahabharata* as *Razmnama*, the *Ramayana*, the *Bhagavad Gita*, the *Atharva Veda*, *Rajatarangini* and Gospel material entered the Persianate courtly sphere. This made the Mughal centre a site where doctrines could be compared in a common learned language. The policy significance lies in two connected moves. First, translation reduced dependence on hearsay and broadened elite access to non-Islamic intellectual traditions. Second, it supported the logic of sulh-i-kul by making plural traditions legible to a court that sought to rule heterogeneous subjects. Yet the programme remained mediated and elite. Pandits, munshis and courtiers filtered the process; rural society did not suddenly become part of a universal conversation. The stronger historical claim is that Akbar's policy moved from oral disputation to textual comparison and thereby deepened the intellectual infrastructure of plural imperial rule.

Demand decoding: "Explain how" asks for mechanism.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Name the bureau and texts, explain what translation enabled, then end with the elite-scale qualification.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because it converts a culture fact into a state-and-ideas argument.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one named translator or pandit if you want to deepen the courtly process rather than only the outcomes.

Original Mains 5 - 20 marks, 250 words

Question: Was Tauhid-i-Ilahi a new religion? Discuss with source caution. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: Tauhid-i-Ilahi should not be described as a new religion in the full institutional sense. Abu'l Fazl's preferred terminology foregrounded divine monotheism, while "Din-i-Ilahi" gained greater force in Badauni's hostile narrative and later retellings. The negative evidence is substantial: there was no scripture, priesthood, public congregation or empire-wide missionary programme. Membership was tiny; Birbal appears as the prominent Hindu name usually cited. Yet the contrary claim - that nothing at all existed - is also false. Sources report initiation, shast, greeting formulas and four degrees of devotion involving property, life, honour and religion. These practices make best sense when compared with Sufi pir-murid idioms and with the political need to bind a heterogeneous elite to the emperor. Therefore Tauhid-i-Ilahi is best understood as a restricted spiritual-political fellowship, not an organised universal religion. Source caution matters because both Abu'l Fazl's idealising tone and Badauni's hostility can distort scale and intention.

Demand decoding: "Discuss with source caution" requires a direct answer to the binary plus explicit handling of terminology and bias.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Move in three steps: what was absent, what was present, why the sources disagree about meaning and scale.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because it rejects both extremes while using the source problem itself as evidence.

How to improve/strengthen: Add Abu'l Fazl versus Badauni explicitly in the opening sentence if you want the source-caution dimension visible earlier.

Original Mains 6 - 20 marks, 250 words

Question: Analyse Akbar's religious policy as a project of plural imperial state formation. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: Akbar's religious policy can be analysed most fruitfully as a project of plural imperial state formation. A conquering Timurid dynasty ruling a heterogeneous realm needed more than military victory; it required a political language that could reduce sectarian distrust without dissolving sovereignty. The project began with selected inclusion through 1563-64 fiscal relief. The Ibadat Khana then exposed the inability of one clerical milieu to command unquestioned authority for the empire. The Mahzar of 1579 strengthened ruler-centred arbitration among juristic disputes, while translation projects and interfaith encounters widened comparative knowledge at the imperial centre. Sulh-i-kul gave these tendencies their most durable formulation by linking justice, public welfare and non-sectarian governance. Still, the project remained early-modern and hierarchical. Chittor, rebellion punishment, unequal social order and the narrow reach of Tauhid-i-Ilahi show that inclusion coexisted with coercion and dependence on the emperor's will. The best verdict is therefore not that Akbar created secular democracy, but that he forged an innovative language of plural rule through which empire could govern diversity more effectively than a narrow sectarian order would allow.

Demand decoding: "Analyse" needs mechanism and relationship.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Open with the empire problem, then show how reforms, debate, Mahzar, translation and sulh-i-kul addressed it, and finish with coercion and hierarchy.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because every named element is tied back to the problem of ruling plurality rather than left as trivia.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one line on composite nobility or grant redistribution if you want the state-formation angle even more institutional.